MODULE 11 · DOMAIN 1 - PEOPLE

Managing conflict

Where conflict comes from, reading its context and intensity, the five ways of handling it, and when each one is right.

DOMAIN I - People EXAM WEIGHT 33% MODULE 11 of 49

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Conflict is not the problem. Unmanaged conflict is.

Task conflict or relationship conflict?

TASK CONFLICT

About the work

- Disagreement on approach or priorities
- Can improve decisions
- Keep it respectful and focused
- Encourage it, within ground rules

RELATIONSHIP CONFLICT

About the people

- Personal friction and blame
- Damages trust and performance
- Often grows from unresolved task conflict
- Address it early and privately

THE TIEBREAKER

Healthy teams disagree about the work and respect each other. Protect the first, prevent the second.

Where project conflict comes from

SOURCE	EXAMPLE
Scarce resources	Two workstreams need the same specialist this week
Schedules and priorities	Whose work goes first when time is short
Technical opinions	Rewrite or patch; which tool; which design
Procedures and roles	Who approves; who is responsible; which process applies
Cost	Budget allocation between teams or scope items
Personal work styles	Detail-focused versus big-picture; fast versus careful

ON THE EXAM

Most project conflict is about resources, priorities and procedures, not personalities. Look there first.

Analyse the context before acting

- **Importance**: how much does the outcome matter to the project and to each party?
- **Relationship**: will these people need to work together afterwards?
- **Time**: is there time for a full discussion, or must something happen today?
- **Intensity**: is this still a problem to solve, or has it become personal?
- **Safety**: is anyone's safety, or a legal obligation, at stake?

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The same disagreement needs different handling at different intensities and time pressures.

How intense is it? Five levels of conflict

LEVEL	WHAT YOU HEAR	WHAT HELPS
1. Problem to solve	'We see this differently'	Collaborate on the problem
2. Disagreement	Self-protection; guarded talk	Build safety, then problem-solve
3. Contest	Taking sides; 'always' and 'never'	Facilitate; separate facts from positions
4. Crusade	Defending the faction; principles over facts	Structured mediation; lower the heat
5. World war	Winning means destroying the other side	Separate the parties; formal intervention

ON THE EXAM

The higher the level, the more structure is needed. Most exam scenarios sit at levels 1 to 3.

The five ways of handling conflict

MODE	ALSO CALLED	WHAT HAPPENS
Collaborating	Problem solving, confronting	A solution meeting both sides' real needs
Compromising	Reconciling	Each side gives something up
Smoothing	Accommodating	Stress agreement; often concede
Forcing	Directing, competing	One view imposed by authority
Withdrawing	Avoiding	Step back, postpone, leave it

ON THE EXAM

Collaborating is usually best. But every mode has a situation where it is the right answer.

Two dimensions behind the five modes

ASSERTIVENESS

Concern for my goals

- High: forcing, collaborating
- Low: smoothing, withdrawing
- Middle: compromising

COOPERATIVENESS

Concern for their goals

- High: smoothing, collaborating
- Low: forcing, withdrawing
- Middle: compromising

THE TIEBREAKER

Collaborating is high on both. That is why it produces win-win outcomes, and why it takes the most time.

When each mode is the right answer

MODE	RIGHT WHEN
Collaborating	The issue matters, the relationship matters, and there is time to explore
Compromising	Time is short, both sides have equal power, and collaboration has stalled
Smoothing	Keeping the relationship matters more than this issue, or to calm things first
Forcing	Safety, legal or ethical obligations, or a true emergency
Withdrawing	Emotions are too high right now, or the issue is trivial or will resolve itself

ON THE EXAM

Forcing is right for safety and law. Withdrawing is right as a brief cooling-off. Neither is a long-term fix.

Who resolves it, and in what order

01

The parties

Encouraged to resolve it directly, as the charter says.

02

Facilitated

The project leader brings them together, privately.

03

Team process

Ground rules, retrospective, decision method.

04

Escalate

Functional manager, sponsor or HR, if unresolved.

ON THE EXAM

The people in conflict own it first. The leader facilitates; escalation is the last step.

Facilitating a conflict conversation

- Meet **privately**, in a neutral setting, with both parties if they are ready.
- Separate **positions** from **interests**: what they demand, and why they need it.
- Agree the facts, then explore options that meet both sides' interests.
- Agree what happens next, write it down, and follow up.
- Taking sides, or ruling on who was right, turns you from facilitator into combatant.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Interests are usually compatible even when positions are not. Find the interests.

Conflict with and between external stakeholders

- The outline asks you to **communicate conflict management principles** to external stakeholders too.
- Anchor disagreements on the **agreed objectives**, the contract, or regulation, not on opinions.
- With suppliers, use the **contract's dispute process**, but talk first.
- Siding automatically with the most senior or most powerful stakeholder is not resolution.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> With external parties, objective criteria settle more disputes than authority does.

Project Lantern: a conflict, resolved

- The data migration lead and the app team both needed the **test database** in the same week.
- **Positions**: each wanted exclusive use for five days.
- **Interests**: migration needed a clean copy for one overnight run; the app team needed daytime testing.
- Resolution: app testing by day, migration's run overnight, with a refresh each morning. Both got what they needed.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Incompatible positions, compatible interests. That is what collaborating finds.

Scenario signals and the move

THE SCENARIO SAYS	THE MOVE
Two people disagree; there is time	Meet them, find interests, collaborate
Deadline today; collaboration has stalled	Compromise
Someone wants to bypass a safety or legal step	Force: the requirement is not negotiable
Voices raised, personal remarks	Pause, cool off, then meet privately
Vigorous but respectful technical debate	Healthy task conflict: protect it
Two powerful stakeholders disagree	Facilitate on objective criteria, not rank

ON THE EXAM

Read the context, then choose the mode. Collaborate by default; the other four have specific triggers.

> The development lead and the test lead are arguing about access to the only performance-test environment. Each has booked it for the same week.
>
> Both have raised the issue separately with the project manager, and the schedule is at risk.

What should the project manager do first?

A. Decide who gets the environment, based on the critical path.

B. Meet both leads to understand what each needs, and facilitate a solution together.

C. Escalate the conflict to both leads' functional managers.

D. Tell the leads to resolve it between themselves by the end of the day.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do first?

A. Decide, using the critical path.
Forcing, before anyone knows whether both needs could be met.

B. Meet both; facilitate together.
Collaborating: finds the interests behind two booked weeks.

C. Escalate to managers.
Too early. Nobody has facilitated a conversation yet.

D. Sort it out yourselves.
Withdrawing. They have already failed to, and brought it to the PM.

THE SIGNAL

A resource conflict with time to talk: collaborate. Positions clash; interests may not.

> On a construction project, a subcontractor's foreman wants to skip a scheduled scaffold safety inspection to hit a milestone on Friday.
>
> The site safety officer insists the inspection must happen. The two are arguing on site.

How should the project manager handle the conflict?

A Require the inspection to go ahead as scheduled, before work continues.

B Agree a shorter, partial inspection as a compromise.

C Emphasise the shared goal of the milestone to calm both parties.

D Leave the foreman and safety officer to agree between themselves.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

How should the project manager handle the conflict?

A Require the inspection.

Forcing is correct when safety is at stake. The requirement is not negotiable.

B Partial inspection.

Compromises on safety. A half inspection is a failed inspection.

C Emphasise the milestone.

Smoothing, and it signals that the milestone outranks safety.

D Let them agree.

Withdrawing from a safety decision the PM must own.

THE SIGNAL

Safety is the one place where forcing is the right answer. Recovery planning comes afterwards.

> Two department heads both need the same data specialist full-time for the next two weeks. Both needs are legitimate and both deadlines are firm.
>
> The project manager has facilitated a discussion, but no creative solution has emerged, and a decision is needed by tomorrow.

Which approach is most appropriate now?

A Assign the specialist to the more senior department head.

B Postpone the decision until one of the deadlines moves.

C Stress how much the two departments agree on, to reduce tension.

D Agree a split of the specialist's time that both department heads can accept.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which approach is most appropriate now?

A Seniority decides.
Forcing by rank. Ignores that both needs are legitimate.

B Postpone.
Withdrawing, when a decision is needed tomorrow.

C Stress agreement.
Smoothing. Pleasant, but it does not allocate the specialist.

D Agree a split.
Compromise fits: collaboration tried, equal claims, time nearly out.

THE SIGNAL

Collaboration tried, equal claims, deadline tomorrow: compromise is the right mode.

> In a design review, a disagreement between the lead architect and a senior developer becomes heated. Voices are raised and the remarks turn personal.
>
> Other attendees look uncomfortable, and the meeting has thirty minutes left.

What should the project manager do?

A Press for a decision now, since everyone is present.

B Call a short break, then meet the two privately once things have calmed.

C Support the architect, since the design is the architect's responsibility.

D Note the behaviour and report it to human resources.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A. Press for a decision now.
Decisions made in anger are poor, and it escalates in front of others.

B. Break, then meet privately.
Temporary withdrawing to cool off, followed by private collaboration.

C. Back the architect.
Takes sides mid-conflict and turns it into a contest.

D. Report to HR.
Premature and formal. One heated meeting needs a conversation first.

THE SIGNAL

When it turns personal, pause first. Withdrawing briefly is right; withdrawing permanently is not.

> An agile team regularly debates design choices vigorously in refinement sessions, but always respectfully, and its delivery is strong.
>
> A newly appointed sponsor observes one session, thinks the team is dysfunctional, and asks the project manager to stop the debates.

What should the project manager do?

A Explain to the sponsor that respectful debate is healthy and improves decisions, and share the team's results.

B Ask the team to stop debating in refinement sessions.

C Replace the most outspoken team members.

D Require all design decisions to be made by majority vote.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Explain healthy debate; show results.

Protects valuable task conflict, and manages the sponsor's perception with evidence.

B Stop the debates.

Suppresses the task conflict that is producing good decisions.

C Replace outspoken members.

Punishes people for doing their job well.

D Majority votes only.

Replaces reasoning with counting, and weakens design quality.

THE SIGNAL

Respectful, work-focused disagreement with strong results is healthy task conflict. Protect it.

> The marketing director wants a product's packaging to claim it is '100% recyclable'. The legal counsel says the claim cannot be supported in two target markets.
>
> Both are senior stakeholders, and each has asked the project manager to support their position.

What should the project manager do?

A Support the marketing director, who is also the project sponsor's peer.

B Let the packaging design team choose between the two positions.

C Facilitate a meeting of both, using the regulations and product objectives to find wording that meets both interests.

D Escalate the disagreement to the chief executive.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Side with marketing.
Sides by status, and ignores a real compliance risk.

B Designers choose.
Pushes a senior, legal-risk decision onto a team that cannot own it.

C Facilitate on regulation and objectives.
Collaborates on objective criteria: likely a claim that is both appealing and lawful.

D Escalate to the chief executive.
Too early. The two have not yet been brought together.

THE SIGNAL

Two senior stakeholders, opposite positions: bring them together and anchor on objective criteria.

Protect task conflict. Collaborate by default. **Force only for safety and law.**

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